Like Auckland, Elphinstone was not known for his decisiveness and, again like Auckland, had spent much of his career depending on the opinions of his assistants. But while it was Auckland's fate to have fallen into the hands of the hawkish Colvin and the pedantic yet undeniably bright Macnaghten, Elphinstone was more unlucky still in that he was given for his deputy one of the most unhelpful, unpleasant and unpopular officers in the entire army.

Brigadier General John Shelton of the 44th Foot was a cantankerous, rude and boorish man who had lost his right arm in the Peninsular War, and the incessant pain he suffered seemed to have darkened and embittered his character. He was a rigid disciplinarian, known to be 'a tyrant to his regiment'. When Captain Colin Mackenzie first saw him marching his troops into the country, he recorded in his diary that Shelton was 'a wretched brigadier. The monstrous confusion which takes place in crossing the rivers from his want of common arrangement is disgraceful, and would be fatal in an avowed enemy's country.'[7] Later, Mackenzie crossed his path a second time and wrote, 'As I expected, Shelton has marched the brigade off its legs . . . The artillery horses are quite done up, those of the cavalry nearly so, and the beasts of burden, camels etc . . . have died in great numbers, and will continue to die from overwork . . . The unnecessary hardship he has exposed the men to, especially during their passage through the Khyber, has caused much discontent. Part of the horse artillery on one occasion actually mutinied.'[8]

The entire cantonment took an instant dislike to Shelton. The surgeon John Magrath, who had come across him before in India, was soon describing him as 'more detested than ever'.[9] Nor did Shelton get on with the gentle and gentlemanly Elphinstone. 'His manner was most contumacious from the day of his arrival,' the Major-General wrote later. 'He never gave me information or advice, but invariably found fault with all that was done and canvassed and condemned all orders before officers – frequently perverting and delaying carrying them into effect. He appeared to be actuated by an ill-feeling towards me.'[10]

Nor did Elphinstone much take to the political officers or the monarch he was going to have to work with. In April 1841, near the end of his journey from Meerut, he arrived at the winter capital of Jalalabad, to which Shuja had again retreated to escape the blizzards of the Kabul winter. 'My